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From Planet Earth

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01 REPORTAGE · INSPIRATION · ROMA

From 8,000 Spots to a World of Folks

The story behind SpotFolk: how a personal collection of places became an idea for a different kind of community.

TEXT AND PHOTOGRAPHS BY **FABIO COSTANTINI** · 8 NOVEMBER 2026



It started with a map.

Over the years, I had collected more than 8,000 locations around the world. Places I had discovered through remote scouting, hours spent exploring satellite images, maps, travel blogs and geographical details, but also through personal experiences, road trips and time spent out in the field.

Some were hidden viewpoints, others forgotten villages, quiet roads, mountain trails, unusual architectural details or simply places that made me stop and look twice.

Each location had something that caught my attention. And gradually, the collection became something much bigger than a personal archive.

I called them *Spots*.

An obsession with finding places

Finding interesting locations has always been part of the way I approach photography and travelling.

Sometimes, discovering a place starts long before actually getting there. I can spend hours exploring a remote area on a map, following a road that seems to

lead nowhere, looking for an unusual coastline or trying to understand how the light might interact with a particular landscape.

Other times, a Spot comes from a completely different experience: a place I stumble upon while travelling, a recommendation from someone, or a location that surprises me when I least expect it.

Remote scouting and real-world exploration eventually became two sides of the same process.

The result was a growing collection of thousands of places, each with its own potential story.

At some point, I started thinking: why should all these discoveries remain mine?

From my map to everyone's map

My first idea was quite simple: make the map public and allow other people to explore my collection.

I wanted to share those 8,000 Spots with photographers, travellers and curious people looking for somewhere different to go.

But the more I thought about it, the more I realised that simply opening my map wasn't enough.

There are millions of interesting places in the world, and no single person could ever discover them all.

What if other people could contribute their own discoveries?

What if a photographer could share a viewpoint, a hiker could add a trail, a traveller could recommend a little village, and someone passionate about food could introduce a place worth travelling for?

The map could become something that grows with its community.

Not just a collection of places, but a shared collection of discoveries.

And that changed everything.

Then came the Folks

The next question was: who are the people behind these places?

Most platforms organise places around ratings, reviews and stars. You visit somewhere, leave a score, write a few lines and move on.

But I always felt something was missing.

A five-star rating doesn't tell me much about the person who gave it. It doesn't tell me what they were looking for, what caught their attention or why they decided that a particular place was worth sharing.

I wanted something more personal.

That's where the idea of the *Folk* came from.

Every user becomes a Folk. Every Spot can carry the signature of the person who discovered it or chose to share it.

A photographer, a hiker, a foodie, a traveller, a digital nomad: different people, different interests, different ways of looking at the world.

And each of them brings something unique to the map.

The interesting part is no longer just the place itself. It's the person behind the discovery.

Less about stars. More about signatures.

I don't think places need another endless competition of ratings and reviews.

What makes a location interesting is often much more subjective than a number.

A hidden viewpoint might be extraordinary to a landscape photographer. A quiet mountain refuge might mean everything to a hiker. A tiny restaurant might become someone's favourite discovery of an entire journey.

None of these experiences needs to be validated by a five-star rating.

Sometimes, knowing who recommends a place is far more valuable than knowing how many stars it has.

That's the idea behind SpotFolk: **your signature makes the Spot worth discovering.**

Not because every recommendation has to be perfect, but because every discovery comes from a real person with their own perspective.

A map that belongs to everyone

SpotFolk is still built around the original idea: discovering interesting places and making them easier to find.

But it has evolved into something more ambitious.

I started with more than 8,000 Spots collected over years of scouting and exploration. Today, I want to see that map grow through the eyes of thousands of different people.

I don't want it to be just my map anymore.

I want it to become a place where photographers, travellers, hikers, food lovers and curious minds can leave their mark, share what they find and discover the world through someone else's eyes.

Because the world doesn't need another list of the best places.

It needs more people willing to share the places they love.

And every Spot deserves a Folk behind it.

Around the fire, there's room for you.

Every great journey is better when shared.

And every good story deserves an audience.

I imagine SpotFolk as a campfire somewhere in the world. A place where people with different backgrounds, passions and experiences gather to share the places they've discovered, the paths they've taken and the stories they've collected along the way.

Some come with photographs. Others with hiking trails, favourite food spots, hidden villages or simply a curiosity to explore.

It doesn't matter what kind of Folk you are. What matters is what you bring to the circle.

So, pull up a seat. There's room around the fire.

Come join the Folks. Discover new places, share your own Spots and leave your signature on the map.

The fire is already burning. We're just waiting for you.

Join SpotFolk → spotfolk.eu

Fabio Costantini

02 FIELD GUIDE · TECHNIQUE

Beyond Detail: Depth, Three-Dimensionality and Photographic Perception

Depth is not sharpness, and three-dimensionality is not contrast. Let's explore how detail, light and shadows shape our perception of space and volume in a photograph.

TEXT AND PHOTOGRAPHS BY **FABIO COSTANTINI** · 4 NOVEMBER 2026 · 7 MIN READ



Beyond Detail: Depth, Three-Dimensionality and Photographic

Perception

There is a fairly widespread habit in photo-editing courses that I have never fully agreed with: treating effects such as Orton and Glow as nothing more than the final stage of photographic processing.

First, you work on the details, recover the highlights, adjust the colours and refine the contrast. Then, when everything seems to be finished, you add a little Orton, a few highlights, perhaps a touch of Glow. Just enough to give the photograph that famous *mood*.

As if these were merely finishing touches, some kind of aesthetic trick applied to an image that was already complete.

I believe this approach is fundamentally limiting.

Orton, Glow and, more generally, atmospheric control are not simply tools for making a photograph look more evocative. They can influence something far more important: the way we perceive space, shapes and volumes within an image.

To understand why, we first need to clarify two concepts that are often confused: depth and three-dimensionality.

1. Depth and Three-Dimensionality: Two Different Concepts

When we talk about photographic depth, we are referring to the perception of space and the distance between the different planes within a scene.

It is what allows us to distinguish between a foreground, a middle ground and a background. It creates the feeling that space exists between the elements in the image, that some are close to us while others gradually recede into the distance.

Three-dimensionality, on the other hand, is about the perception of volume.

It is what allows us to recognise the shape of an object, understand its structure and perceive its illuminated surfaces, curves and shadowed areas.

These two aspects are closely related, but they are not the same.

Imagine a mountain landscape. We may have a very strong sense of depth, created by the succession of planes and atmospheric perspective, while the mountains themselves appear flat, almost like overlapping silhouettes.

Conversely, we may have a tree whose three-dimensional form is perfectly defined, with a clear sense of volume in its canopy and trunk, yet it may be placed within a scene that conveys very little sense of depth.

This distinction is important because it helps us understand that the three-dimensionality of an individual element does not necessarily determine the depth of the entire scene. Likewise, a clear separation between planes does not guarantee that the objects within them will be perceived as having volume.

Photography must therefore work on both levels: on the one hand, establishing spatial relationships between the different planes; on the other, conveying the shape and volume of the elements that make up the scene.

And this brings us to a fundamental point: increasing clarity or microcontrast does not automatically produce greater depth or three-dimensionality.

In fact, in many cases, it can produce exactly the opposite result.

2. Hierarchy: The Real Secret Behind the Perception of Space

The first thing we need to understand is that our eyes do not perceive every element in a scene in the same way.

When we look at a landscape, we do not register every detail with equal intensity, assign the same importance to every light source or perceive all contrasts with the same strength.

Distance, atmospheric conditions, the direction of light and the shape of objects constantly influence our perception.

This means that, to create a convincing sense of depth and three-dimensionality, we need to respect a certain hierarchy.

I consider three elements essential:

- Detail.
- Light.
- Contrast, understood as the relationship between highlights and shadows.

These elements affect both depth and three-dimensionality, but in different ways.

Detail: Not Everything Needs to Be Equally Defined

Let's start with depth.

Imagine a landscape photograph with a foreground, a middle ground and a mountainous background.

If every element has the same amount of detail, the same sharpness and the same level of definition, the image loses an important part of its spatial information.

In reality, the visibility of detail generally decreases with distance. The atmosphere, humidity and particles suspended in the air all contribute to reducing the visibility of textures and shapes in more distant areas.

The foreground may therefore contain a greater richness of detail, the middle ground progressively less definition, and the background a more delicate presence.

This does not mean that we necessarily have to blur everything that is far away. It means that we cannot expect every plane to have the same level of sharpness.

Detail also plays an important role in three-dimensionality, but its function is different.

The way detail is distributed helps describe the surfaces of objects: a rock, tree bark, a leaf or a mountain all have different characteristics that our eyes use to understand their structure.

However, indiscriminately emphasising every texture can compromise the perception of volume. If every surface displays the same amount of microcontrast, we risk turning the entire scene into a succession of competing textures.

Detail must therefore follow a hierarchy, both spatially and perceptually.

Light: Not Every Highlight Should Compete for Attention

The second element is light.

Here too, one of the most common mistakes is treating every bright area as if it had the same importance.

When it comes to depth, light helps us distinguish between different planes and establish a sense of spatial progression.

Imagine a landscape where the foreground is relatively dark, the middle ground is illuminated by sunlight, and the mountains in the background are immersed in soft light.

This distribution of light helps separate the elements and suggest distance.

The background does not necessarily have to be darker or brighter than the foreground. What matters is that there is a coherent relationship between the different areas of the image.

When it comes to three-dimensionality, however, light takes on a more specific role: it describes volume.

It is through the way light falls across surfaces that we perceive curves, protrusions and recesses in an object.

Side lighting, for example, can reveal the structure of a rock, showing the transition between illuminated surfaces and areas in shadow.

Front lighting, on the other hand, can reduce the perception of volume because it tends to produce more uniform illumination across surfaces facing the viewer.

Here, too, a fundamental principle applies: not every highlight should compete for attention.

If every element is illuminated with the same intensity, we lose visual hierarchy. If every area demands our attention, the eye no longer knows where to look.

Contrast: Separating Planes and Shaping Volume

The third element is contrast.

However, we need to distinguish between two different functions.

The first concerns spatial separation between planes.

In reality, contrast generally decreases with distance, mainly due to atmospheric effects. Distant mountains often show less separation between highlights and shadows than nearby elements.

This phenomenon is one of the main visual cues our brain uses to interpret depth.

If we apply the same level of contrast to every plane, we risk eliminating this perceptual difference.

The second function, on the other hand, concerns three-dimensionality.

The contrast between light and shadow is what allows us to describe the shape of surfaces and perceive the volume of objects.

Think of a rock illuminated from the side: the transition between the illuminated area, the midtones and the shadows allows us to understand its shape.

If we completely eliminate these differences, the rock loses its volume and becomes a flat surface.

Conversely, if we increase contrast indiscriminately, we risk making shadows too deep and highlights too harsh, compromising the natural appearance of the object's form.

Contrast must therefore be carefully balanced according to what we want to achieve: separating planes or describing volume.

3. Two Goals, One Image

At this point, we can bring everything together.

Depth and three-dimensionality require different approaches, but they are not independent of one another.

To create depth, we need to work on the hierarchy between planes: the visibility of detail, the distribution of light and the gradual reduction of contrast.

To create three-dimensionality, we need to focus instead on shaping individual elements: the relationship between illuminated and shadowed surfaces, the distribution of midtones and the presence of contrast that defines form.

In both cases, we should avoid indiscriminately increasing the amount of information in the photograph.

We need to organise it.

And that is precisely the difference between a photograph that is simply sharp and one that has been visually constructed.

The first displays a great deal of detail. The second determines which details should stand out, which highlights should attract attention and which contrasts should define space and form.

This is where atmospheric control comes into play.

Orton and Glow, for example, are not simply aesthetic effects to be applied to a photograph that is already finished. They are tools that can help modify the relationship between sharp and diffused information, between light and shadow, and between elements that stand out and those that blend into their surroundings.

Their role (and that of other tools, too) is therefore not to add some generic *mood effect*, but to take an active part in constructing the image.

And this is precisely what we will explore in the next article: how to use Orton, Glow and Photoshop tools to influence the perception of space, shape volumes and build photographic atmosphere.

03 FIELD GUIDE · TECHNIQUE · ROMA

Building FabioCostaPh: From an Idea to a Website

A behind-the-scenes look at how I designed and built my own photography platform, from the first sketches to the final launch.

TEXT AND PHOTOGRAPHS BY **FABIO COSTANTINI** · 2 NOVEMBER 2026 · 7 MIN READ



01. It all started with an idea

I'm a photographer, not a web developer. At least, that's how this story started.

I wanted a place to collect my photographs, share the locations behind them and create something useful for other photography enthusiasts.

A simple portfolio? That was the original plan.

But, as often happens with photography, things got a little more complicated. One idea led to another, new features started taking shape, and before I knew it, I was building something much bigger than a traditional photography website.

That's how FabioCostaPh came to life.

The idea was to create a digital space combining three things I really enjoy: photography, travelling and discovering new places.

I didn't want just another website displaying beautiful pictures. I wanted something people could actually use, explore and contribute to.

02. Planning before coding

Before writing a single line of code, I needed to understand what I wanted to build.

The first step was planning the website's structure. I divided the project into different sections, each with its own purpose.

Home: the main entrance to the project.

Gallery: a collection of my landscape and urban photography.

Explore: a way to discover interesting places.

Spots: an interactive map where photography locations and other points of interest can be shared.

Tools: practical resources designed for photographers.

Journal: articles, guides and behind-the-scenes stories.

About: a little introduction to the person behind the camera.

Once the structure was clear, I started thinking about how everything should look and, more importantly, how people would move through the website.

This is where two important concepts came into play: UX and UI.

UX (User Experience) is about how people interact with a website. Is it easy to navigate? Can visitors find what they're looking for without getting lost?

UI (User Interface) is about the visual side: colours, typography, buttons, menus, layouts and all the little details that make a website feel coherent.

I wanted a clean, modern interface with a dark colour palette, subtle golden details and a visual identity that reflected the atmosphere of photography and exploration.

03. The tools behind the website

Once the structure and visual direction were defined, it was time to build.

I used a combination of technologies, each with a specific job.

HTML – Building the structure

HTML stands for HyperText Markup Language.

Think of it as the skeleton of a website. It defines the content and its structure: headings, paragraphs, images, buttons, links and individual sections.

Without HTML, there would be no actual page to display.

CSS – Making everything look right

CSS stands for Cascading Style Sheets.

If HTML is the skeleton, CSS is the design.

It controls colours, fonts, spacing, dimensions, layouts, animations and how the website adapts to different screen sizes.

It's what makes the same basic structure look like a carefully designed photography platform rather than a plain document.

JavaScript – Bringing the website to life

JavaScript is what makes a website interactive.

It handles things such as navigation menus, image filters, interactive elements, dynamic content and communication with external services.

In simple terms, HTML provides the structure, CSS handles the appearance and JavaScript makes things happen.

Visual Studio Code – The development environment

Visual Studio Code (VS Code) was my main workspace.

It's a code editor that allows you to create, organise and edit all the files that make up a website.

HTML, CSS and JavaScript files can be managed in one place, making it easier to work on different parts of the project without losing track of everything.

Supabase – Where the data lives

A website with interactive features needs somewhere to store information.

That's where Supabase comes in.

Supabase is a backend platform built around PostgreSQL, a relational database system.

It can manage information such as registered users, shared locations, articles and other content.

It also provides services for authentication, file storage and communication with the database.

In other words, it provides much of the infrastructure needed to turn a collection of web pages into a platform that can store and manage real information.

GitHub Pages – Putting the website online

Once the website started taking shape, I needed somewhere to publish it.

I chose GitHub Pages.

GitHub is a platform used to store and manage code. It also keeps track of changes, making it possible to maintain different versions of a project and recover previous work when necessary.

GitHub Pages allows you to publish a website directly from a GitHub repository.

This means that, once the files are uploaded and configured, the website can be made publicly accessible without having to manage a traditional web server.

It's a particularly convenient solution for websites built with HTML, CSS and JavaScript.

04. Building the website, one section at a time

Rather than trying to build everything at once, I approached the project one section at a time.

I started with the homepage, establishing the overall visual identity and navigation.

Then I moved on to the individual sections, making sure they shared the same design language.

The Gallery

The Gallery was one of the most important parts of the project.

After all, photography is where everything began.

I wanted visitors to browse my photographs through dedicated categories, with a clean layout that allowed the images to take centre stage.

Explore and Spots

This was where the project started becoming something more than a portfolio.

The idea behind Spots was to create a place where photographers could discover and share interesting locations.

Instead of simply displaying a map, I wanted to build a system where each location could have its own information and become part of a growing collection.

Tools

The Tools section was designed around a simple idea: photographers often need several different resources to plan a single shot.

Bringing useful tools together in one place seemed like a natural extension of the project.

Journal

Finally, I wanted a space for articles, practical guides and experiences.

Not just travel stories, but useful information that other photographers might find interesting.

05. Connecting everything

Building individual pages is one thing. Making them communicate with each other is another.

This is where the database becomes particularly important.

For example, a location submitted by a user can be stored in Supabase and then retrieved by the website to display it on the map.

The same information can potentially be used elsewhere, such as in a location page or a photography collection.

This is one of the most interesting aspects of the project: different sections can share the same information instead of working as completely separate systems.

The idea is to create an interconnected platform where the content added in one place can become useful in several others.

06. Testing, fixing and improving

Of course, things don't always work perfectly the first time.

Buttons need testing, layouts need adjusting and unexpected bugs occasionally appear.

I had to check how the website behaved on different screen sizes, make sure navigation worked properly and verify that the various sections communicated as expected.

Responsive design was particularly important.

A photography website needs to look good on a large desktop monitor, but it also needs to work comfortably on a smartphone.

There is no point creating a beautiful interface if people struggle to use it on their phones.

Testing and fixing are not really separate from development. They are part of the process.

07. Going live

Once the main structure and features were ready, it was time to publish the website.

I connected the project to GitHub Pages and configured the domain.

I also integrated Umami, an analytics platform that allows me to understand how people use the website.

It provides information such as:

Visitors: how many unique visitors access the website.

Visits: how many browsing sessions take place.

Views: how many times pages are viewed.

Popular pages: which sections attract the most attention.

These numbers are particularly interesting because they help me understand which parts of the project people find most useful.

It's also a way to identify what deserves further development.

08. What's next?

FabioCostaPh is not a finished product. It's an evolving project.

There are features I want to improve, ideas I haven't implemented yet and plenty of things I'd like to experiment with.

The long-term goal is to make it more than just my personal photography website.

I'd like it to become a useful space for photographers and travellers: somewhere to discover places, share experiences, find inspiration and plan new adventures.

What started as a simple portfolio has turned into a much bigger project.

And this is only the beginning.

Thanks for stopping by. Now, let's go explore.

Field Notes

From Planet Earth

A monthly issue made of the stories published on **fabiocostaph.com**. A new issue grows on the site every month and closes on its last day.

Want to write for the next issue? Go to **fabiocostaph.com/#write**.

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